The uprising was indigenous, but Pakistan moved quickly to exploit the situation. Its objectives were two-fold: to make Indian-administered Kashmir such a burden that India would abandon it; and to bleed India at little cost to Pakistan. The army and ISI quickly began moving to reorient the direction of the insurgency. The JKLF, which was leading the rebellion, was committed to independence for Kashmir and not accession to Pakistan. According to Amanullah Khan, one of the founders of the JKLF, the ISI requested the group stop calling for sovereignty and instead focus on self-determination. Khan rejected the request, putting it at odds with the Pakistani state. Not long after, the ISI cut off aid to the JKLF and undertook a dual approach to shape the insurgency.[16] First, it encouraged JKLF members to break away and form pro-Pakistani militant groups. Second, it built up Hizb-ul-Mujahideen [Party of Holy Warriors or HM]—the newly-founded militant wing of the Jamaat-e-Islami's branch in Indian-administered Kashmir—as a rival to the JKLF.[17] Because it was still the dominant insurgent group at the time, the JKLF remained the Indian security forces' main target. By roughly 1992 the JKLF was facing a three-front threat: from India, from splinter groups and from HM.[18]

HM's agenda met with resistance from the Kashmiri population for several reasons. First, HM's goal was accession to Pakistan and not independence. Second, the group was part of the Islamist Jamaat-e-Islami Jammu and Kashmir [JIJK] and was committed to establishing an Islamic state, which most Kashmiri Muslims had no interest in. However, HM also had several factors working in its favor. The Jamiat-e-Talaba [the JIJK's student wing] provided support to the HM, especially in the area of recruitment from the Kashmiri population. The appearance of anti-Muslim Hindu groups made the HM's Islamism more appealing to some of the local population. Rising anti-Muslim and Hindu nationalist sentiment in India helped too.[19] Ironically, the Indians did their part by arresting a number of JKLF leaders and killing others. On their own these factors might not have been enough to enable HM to predominate, but it had a trump card: Pakistan.

The Pakistani government increased its support for militancy in Indian-administered Kashmir and pumped a great amount of that support into HM.[20] In turn, HM devoted a significant portion of its resources and recruits to destroying the JKLF. Its operatives brutalized and murdered a